Ananda Coomaraswamy, a Brahmin scholar, art historian and Tamil nationalist who scandalised his contemporaries by marrying a succession of English, American and Argentinian wives but nevertheless made it his life's mission to educate Westerners about Indian art in general and Tamil art in particular.

After the break-up of the EICo in 1858 all the artworks in the Company's museum in Leadenhall Street had been divided between the British Museum and the Victoria and Albert Museum (V&A). According to the first official handbook to the V&A's Indian section, the Indian sculptures so acquired were without artistic merit and, for the most part, 'puerile and detestable'. The attitudes of British historians of India such as Vincent Smith, author of the first edition of *The Oxford History of India*, published in 1904, were equally dismissive – unless, of course, that art was perceived to have been influenced by Greek aesthetics.

Havell challenged these prejudices in his book *Indian Sculpture and Painting*, published in 1908. 'Indian art is essentially idealistic, mystic, symbolic and transcendental,' he wrote. 'I hope I have succeeded in showing that the Indian ideal is not, as archaeologists call it, a decadent and degenerate copy of a Graeco-Roman prototype; that Indian fine art is not, as an Anglo-Indian critic puts it, a form of artistic cretinism, but an opening into a new world of aesthetic thought, full of the deepest interest, and worthy of the study of all Western artists.'

According to Havell, one of the finest examples of Hindu sculpture was to be found in the Madras Museum. It was a Chola bronze of Shiva as Nataraja, 'remarkable, not only for extraordinary technical and decorative skill, but for the consummate art with which the abstract ideas of Hindu philosophy are realised … It is wonderful how the movement of this bronze, in all its seeming naiveté, embodies the mystic ideal of divine ecstasy.'